



## Commission decides to refer Finland to the Court of Justice of the European Union for failing to align its rules with the Seveso III Directive

Brussels, 1 October 2026

Today, the European Commission decided to refer **Finland** ([INFR\(2020\)2218](#)) to the Court of Justice of the European Union for failing to align its rules with the Seveso III Directive ([Directive 2012/18/EU](#)).

The Directive aims to prevent major accidents (for instance, major emissions, fires, or explosions) involving dangerous substances, especially chemicals, and to limit their negative impact on human health and the environment. It applies to around 11,000 industrial installations in the European Union, for instance in the chemical and petrochemical industry, as well as fuel wholesale and storage sectors.

Finland still has not correctly transposed the Directive in particular with regard to inspections, access to information for public, and access to justice. These are important matters impacting effectiveness of national enforcement and giving rights to citizens.

In particular, where reports or inventories of dangerous substances include confidential or sensitive information – for instance related to public security or national defence –, Finland's national rules do not enable Finnish national authorities to disclose other non-sensitive or non-confidential parts of those reports or inventories.

Furthermore, Finland's national rules do not ensure that, where possible, inspections of establishments are coordinated and combined with other inspections under Union legislation. This can lead to fragmented oversight and less efficient enforcement.

The Commission sent a [letter of formal notice](#) to Finland in July 2020 and a [reasoned opinion](#) in December 2025. The Commission considers that efforts by the Finnish authorities to take the steps necessary to amend the national legislation have been insufficient and is therefore referring Finland to the Court of Justice of the European Union.

### Background

On 10 July 1976, a major industrial accident in Seveso, Italy led to thousands of people and vast areas being exposed to a cloud of toxic dioxin – a persistent environmental pollutant. Following this incident, the EU took decisive steps to prevent and control such accidents by adopting the [Seveso Directive](#), which entered into force in 1982. This groundbreaking law led to a [significant reduction of risk of major accidents in the EU](#), reducing harm to people, property and nature, and inspired similar laws and safety standards worldwide.

Today, the Seveso Directive remains the backbone of the EU's industrial safety framework, providing stricter risk assessments, safer land-use planning, stronger safety management and better emergency preparedness. Concretely, companies must prevent major accidents and limit their consequences, while authorities ensure oversight and public safety.

Strict rules apply to installations handling high amounts of dangerous substances, for instance on inspections and access to information.

### For more information

[EU infringement procedure](#)

[Infringement decisions database](#) and [infringements map and graphs](#)

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